

Early coins

Lydian coin

Where Lydia (modern-day Turkey)

When c. 600 BCE

The earliest known coins were minted by people from the ancient kingdom of Lydia. The coins were made from a mixture of gold and silver called electrum and depicted a lion's head.



Paper currency

Song paper money

Where China

When 11th century CE

Under the Song Dynasty, China issued *jiaozi*—the world's first paper money. Though the paper had no value in itself, people were willing to use *jiaozi* as money because they could be exchanged for coins, made of gold or silver, at any time.



Three men carry sacks of grain in this modern copy of a Song-era jiaozi.

Global currency

Pieces of eight

Where Spain

When 16th century

The Spanish dollar was the first international currency, thanks to the reach of the extensive Spanish Empire. Made from soft silver, Spanish dollars were known as “pieces of eight” because they could be cut up into eight pieces to make smaller change.



Cryptocurrency

Bitcoin

Where Worldwide

When 2009

A type of digital-only money, cryptocurrency such as Bitcoin is controlled by its users and an algorithm (a set of computer rules) rather than by governments. It allows users to safely make payments or store money without using a bank.



Borrowed money

Credit card

Where US

When 1946

The first bank-issued credit card was the Charg-It in 1946. Credit cards allow people to purchase goods but pay for them at a later date. It was only after banking was computerized that debit cards, which took money from the users' bank accounts instantly, were introduced.

